

## Q I think I may be pregnant. How do I find out for sure?

A urine test is the quickest and simplest way to measure whether you have high levels of the pregnancy hormone human chorionic gonadotrophin (hCG) in your body, which starts rising several days after conception.

You can buy a pregnancy testing kit from a pharmacy or a supermarket to use at home, or you can go to your doctor's office to have them perform an in-office lab test.

Most home testing kits can be used on the first day of your missed period; any earlier, and the test is less reliable (see graph, below). However, some brands claim to provide an accurate result up to four days before your period is due.

If you have irregular periods and you aren't sure when the first day of your missed period will be, do a test three weeks after you last had unprotected sex.

### How to test

It is advisable, but not essential, to do the test soon after you wake in the morning since your urine has the highest concentration of hormones at that time. You simply urinate on the test stick for a few seconds and wait for the positive or negative symbol or the words "Pregnant" or "Not Pregnant" to appear on the screen. The result should show on the screen within a couple of minutes. If you follow the instructions correctly, a positive result means you are almost certainly pregnant. If you have a negative result and your period still hasn't

arrived, you may have tested too early. Although any delay can feel incredibly frustrating, it's worthwhile to wait a few days before testing again.

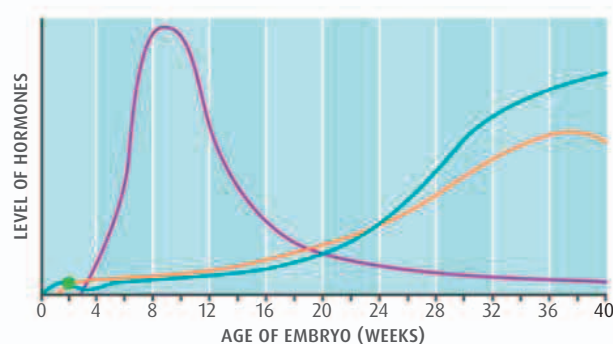
Doctors accept pregnancy home testing kits as accurate. If there is any doubt, a blood test may be done to detect the exact levels of hCG in your body, even if those levels are still low. This may be recommended if you are undergoing fertility treatment.



**Testing at home** Pregnancy testing kits are usually easy-to-use sticks that test the hormone levels in your urine.

## HCG LEVELS IN PREGNANCY

The hormone that signals you are pregnant is called hCG. As the graph shows, hCG levels start rising a week after conception—a little at first and then steadily until your baby is well-established in the uterus. The other main pregnancy hormones, estrogen and progesterone, surge later on.



### KEY

- Human chorionic gonadotrophin (hCG)
- Estrogen
- Progesterone
- Conception

**Increased hormones** Note the huge surge in hCG (the purple line) following conception.

## Q My home pregnancy test result is positive. Can I be sure it's right? What happens next?

**A positive pregnancy test result means you have raised levels of the pregnancy hormone hCG in your body.** Even if the positive symbol or words on the test screen are faint, you are still likely to be pregnant. Many women often do another test just to make sure (many home pregnancy tests come in a double pack), though this isn't necessary.

Make an appointment with your doctor as soon as you can to let him or her know you are pregnant. At the appointment you will find out about your prenatal care and have the chance to

ask questions. Many women schedule this first appointment so they see the doctor when they are about 6 or 8 weeks pregnant.

Your doctor will want to discuss nutrition and lifestyle with you and ensure you know about taking folic acid (see p.49). He or she will also discuss your medical history in case you need additional prenatal screenings or need to adapt any current medication.

Your doctor will give you an estimated delivery date (EDD). You can use a due-date calendar to figure out your EDD yourself (see p.42). They are most useful if you have a regular menstrual cycle: simply look up the first date of your last menstrual period to find your EDD. However, it's an estimate and only 4 percent of women give birth on their EDD. Some doctors do

an ultrasound at the initial appointment (between 7 and 9 weeks). Others wait until 11–14 weeks. If you've had a miscarriage, have a suspected ectopic pregnancy, or you're experiencing bleeding, an earlier scan may be recommended.

**The accuracy of home pregnancy tests is more than 99 percent. So if it says "pregnant" on that little screen, you can be fairly certain that you are!**